Philosophy 25B

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Spinoza's Necessitarianism

Baruch de Spinoza was an influential rationalist philosopher in the 17th century who developed a powerful system of conducting philosophy that is still relevant today. He additionally challenged many popular institutions and schools of thought such as Biblical Scripture and sectarian religion, and he devoted his metaphysics to a highly radical view of God, the universe, and epistemology. In his book *Ethics*, Spinoza acknowledges the existence of God, a substance with infinite attributes, but supports the view that God has no free will and instead God produced things in the way that He did because there is no other metaphysically possible way. This was a contradiction to modern thinkers such as Descartes, who viewed God in a more traditional, benevolent sense. To Spinoza, God is neither good or bad; He just is. I seek to reconstruct Spinoza's argument for necessitarianism through the premises, definitions, and axioms that support it, and then elaborate further on my objection to his methodology. First, I will define the key terms and concepts used by Spinoza in his proof. These definitions of Spinoza's are paramount in understanding the rest of his argument. Then, I will iterate over the arguments for the existence of God and substance monism, a proof which is necessary in reconstructing the aforementioned argument for necessitarianism. Next, I will reconstruct Spinoza's argument against the possibility of a God with free will and in favor of necessitarianism by explaining the premises it was built on and what Spinoza concludes from those premises. Finally, I will end by explaining my objection to Spinoza's method of reasoning

and how this objection finds some success in challenging the validity of Spinoza's argument by targeting its foundations.

Spinoza begins his argument by laying out key definitions and axioms before delving into his premises. This is step one in his geometrical method of reasoning; a method that mimics the structure of proofs found in mathematics. Spinoza uses vocabulary commonplace in metaphysical writing. He defines substance as that which is self-caused, self-sustaining, and self-explanatory (Spinoza, E1D3). He also defines a mode as an affection of a substance, and an attribute as what makes up the essence of a substance (E1D4-D5). These second two definitions can be displayed in an example from Spinoza's modal metaphysics. Examples of attributes are extension and thought. These two attributes are mutually exclusive. Furthermore, examples of modes are shape and size for extended things or belief and desire for thinking things. These modes cannot exist independent of their substance with a certain attribute existing. Spinoza then defines God. Spinoza's God is not an anthropomorphism or benevolent creator. Rather, He is an absolutely infinite being. This infinitude is derived from God being a substance consisting of infinite attributes, which, following the definition of an attribute, express His infinite essences (E1D6). After defining his terms, Spinoza follows up with axioms which he believes are self-evident and widely accepted. The most commonly utilized of Spinoza's axioms is the idea that from a given determinate cause, there necessarily follows an effect; conversely, if there is no cause, there is no effect (E1A3). I will explain why axioms such as this are a weak point in his argument in my objection.

The most important premise for Spinoza's proof of necessitarianism is his proof of monism and his proof of God's existence. In his proof of monism, Spinoza seeks to establish the existence of only one substance. Spinoza opens this argument by reiterating the hierarchy

consisting of substances, attributes, and modes: modes cannot exist without attributes which in turn cannot exist without their substances (E1P1). He then extrapolates that there cannot be more than a single substance with certain attributes, as if there was another substance with identical attributes then it would be the same substance, hence there would only be one (E1P5). Furthermore, substances cannot cause other substances because to do so would require that the substances have something in common with one another(E1P6). This would require the substances to have either attributes or modes in common with each other, which is impossible due to common modes being derived from common attributes which are in turn derived from common substances (E1P2). Common substances were just proven to be nonexistent because they would be the same singular substance (E1P5). Then, Spinoza can claim that existence is a property of the nature of substances because nothing else can cause them to exist (E1P7). Following that claim, Spinoza deduces that every substance is necessarily infinite because substances can only be limited by identical substances, which again do not exist (E1P8). These premises culminate in three proofs for the existence of God: an ontological argument, a causal argument, and a cosmological argument.

Spinoza's ontological argument for the existence of God is straightforward. God is a substance with infinite attributes, and existence is a necessary essence of substances, so God therefore exists (E1P11). The causal argument follows a similar pattern to his arguments concerning the natures of substances. God's non-existence cannot be caused by an external substance to God, as this would mean that this substance would have something in common with God which would make it God. And if this substance had nothing in common with God, then it could not cause God's non-existence. Additionally, if God's non-existence was caused by something internal to God, then this would still require the existence of God for there to be

something internal to Him. This is contradictory and cannot be the case. Therefore, God must exist (E1P11). Finally, Spinoza's cosmological argument rests on the idea that existence is more potent than non-existence. We know that we, finite substances, exist. Therefore, God, an infinite substance, must also exist lest He, an infinite substance, be weaker than us, finite substances, which is an impossibility. Therefore God must exist (E1P11). From this proof of God's existence, Spinoza births his argument for monism. He claims that an infinite substance cannot be divisible due to the nature of infinitude, and thus the infinite substance of God is the only substance that can be. All other things are merely attributes or modes of God. God is the only substance; Monism is true (E1P14).

Following this, Spinoza arrives at the conclusion that "Things could not have been produced by God in any other way or in any other order than is the case" (E1P33). This is Spinoza's necessitarianism. This is the only metaphysically possible world. Spinoza proves this claim by means of *reductio ad absurdum*. His argument is the following:

1. **HYPOTHESIS**: Assume that things, God's nature, could have been otherwise. In other words, assume that necessitarianism is false.
2. For God's nature to be otherwise, there would need to be another substance or God.
3. That other substance or God would need to exist.
4. If that substance exists, then there is more than one substance.
5. Monism would therefore be false.
6. **Absurdity:** Monism has already been proven to be true (E1P14).
7. *Reductio:* We must negate the **HYPOTHESIS**

C: Things, God's nature, could not have been otherwise, and necessitarianism is true.

This argument presented by Spinoza seems valid. If X could only be when Y, and Y contradicts a previously proven Z, then Y can never be and therefore X can never be and X's contradiction must be the case. This proof establishes the claim that God has no free will – He simply performs in a predetermined, necessary motion. In other words, this is the only metaphysically possible world.

Spinoza's logic seems airtight. He begins with simple definitions and lays out each step of his analytic process, constructing proofs where necessary to follow his line of reasoning. My objection to Spinoza, however, is not his logic. It is his methodology. His application of a geometric method style of reasoning appears well and good in theory for metaphysical proofs, but closer analysis reveals that this method of reasoning is not applicable to philosophical writings. Geometrical proofs work well in mathematics because the definitions, axioms, corollaries, and postulates of mathematics are unanimously and unambiguously agreed upon. They can be deconstructed out of language and into the symbols and diagrams upon which they are based. A mathematical proof does not necessitate words to convey its point – the words only help to describe it. Philosophical proofs, on the other hand, can only be done through words. Words are imperfect interpretations of reality, unlike mathematical diagrams which convey the patterns of logic impeccably. Therefore, it is critical that the words used are used correctly. The definitions Spinoza begins his work with attempt to reconcile this. However, these definitions and axioms are not the same as their mathematical counterparts, in that they are only Spinoza's definitions. These words will also never be able to achieve what their mathematical counterparts can simply due to their imperfect nature. Although some may agree with him, it seems that Spinoza does not recognize the power of certain definitions and axioms that he gives no justification for. Because Spinoza controls the definitions, he therefore controls the argument. He

cannot fail to support whatever conclusion he wishes to make, and he can quell any objection that arises to it.

Spinoza may respond to this by raising the question of how one is to go about proving their metaphysics if they cannot construct proofs. He may make the claim that a geometrical method of reasoning is the closest thing we have to a perfect logical argument system, and despite its shortcomings outside of mathematics, we should still take advantage of the degree of certainty it has to offer. Spinoza may also make the claim that someone has to define key terms, and getting everyone to agree on each concept would be an impossible feat. He simply has done the best anyone could do with the imperfect tools he was given.